



Start-up Champion

INDIA IS HOME to 75,000 start-ups in the 75th year of Independence and this is only the beginning, Union Minister **Piyush Goyal** tweeted. Over 750,000 jobs have been created by start-ups. As per data from the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, the latest 10,000 start-ups were recognised in 156 days, compared to 808 days for the initial 10,000. India, the third largest start-up ecosystem in the world, raised a record \$35 billion and 43 start-ups turned into unicorns in 2021, according to PwC data.

—BINU PAUL

TELECOM WARRIOR

During a recent interaction with employees of BSNL, Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister of Communications, was heard warning them to start delivering results within two years or face the axe. In a leaked five-minute clip, the minister was heard saying that their performance would be appraised monthly. With the Union Cabinet approving a ₹1.64-lakh crore lifeline for BSNL, it's time for the carrier to stand up and be counted.

—MANISH PANT



THE BIG CALL

MUKESH AMBANI-LED Reliance Jio is set to gain an advantage over Airtel as it bought a total of 24,740 MHz of 5G spectrum including 220 MHz in the 700 MHz band in all 22 circles, which will give it huge coverage for fewer towers. According to BofA Securities, Jio would be able to offer true low-latency applications: "It will be difficult for peers to offer the same given the lack of spectrum. All of this could help Jio poach high-end customers from its competitors."

—PRERNA LIDHOO

Show me the Money



For AJAY SINGH, promoter of cash-strapped airline SpiceJet, the top priority is recapitalisation. He is said to be in dialogue with investors, including a Middle-Eastern carrier, which could potentially pick up a 24 per cent stake. A deal will be a shot in the arm for SpiceJet as the battle for the skies gets even more intense.

—KRISHNA GOPALAN



CONFUSION REIGNS

Who owns WazirX? In November 2019, Binance had announced the buyout of WazirX. But after the ED launched a probe into Zangmai Labs, Binance CEO **Changpeng Zhao** tweeted that Binance doesn't own any equity in Zangmai that owns WazirX. Then, WazirX CEO Nischal Shetty tweeted that Zangmai is a separate entity, while Binance owns the WazirX domain name, has root access to AWS servers, and retains all its profits and crypto assets. We're confused.

—TEENA JAIN KAUSHAL

A Harsh Message

MASAYOSHI SON picks his words carefully. The Founder of SoftBank has faced a rough quarter with a loss of \$23 billion, driven primarily by the poor performance of his Vision Fund and a foreign exchange loss. Not holding back, the message from him was clear as he warned of job cuts and that the "loss is the biggest in our corporate history and we take it very seriously". How valuations will play out from here will be closely watched.

—KRISHNA GOPALAN

THE GOOD DOC

Mansukh Mandaviya, Union Minister of Health & Family Welfare, said in Parliament that the central government has opened nearly 200 million health accounts under Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission. He said every Indian will have OTP-protected digital health accounts. Good move.

—NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA



MANSUKH MANDAVIYA & ASHWINI VAISHNAW PHOTOS BY YASIR IQBAL;
PIYUSH GOYAL PHOTO BY BANDEEP SINGH